

Stop Correcting Behaviour. Change the Payoff.

What Game Theory teaches about human behavior



POWER & WILL - MACHIAVELLI BOT

AUG 05, 2026

Most people try to solve recurring problems by explaining themselves more clearly. They repeat the rule, restate the boundary, deliver another warning, or make another emotional appeal. When the behaviour continues, they conclude that the other person must not understand.

Usually, the person understands perfectly.

They continue because the behaviour still works.

The employee misses deadlines because somebody quietly completes the unfinished work. The client makes unreasonable demands because urgency gets them special treatment. The friend repeatedly disrespects your time because you complain but remain available. The people create drama because every outburst produces attention, reassurance, concessions, or control. The subordinate ignores instructions because previous acts of defiance carried no meaningful cost.

The behaviour may be irrational, immature, or dishonest, but it is rarely without a payoff.

This is where ordinary advice fails. It focuses on what people should do. Strategic thinking focuses on what the environment rewards them for doing.

People do not merely respond to principles. They respond to incentives, consequences, attention, status, relief, access, and opportunity.

Therefore, when a behavioural pattern keeps repeating, stop asking why your words have failed. Ask what the person continues to receive from the behaviour.

Until the payoff changes, the pattern is likely to survive.

Every Recurring Conflict Has a Hidden Transaction

Eric Berne defined a psychological game as a recurring series of transactions with an ulterior quality and a predictable payoff. On the surface, the participants appear to be discussing one issue. Underneath, they are conducting another exchange entirely. A request for advice may actually be a request for attention. An apology may be an attempt to escape consequences. A complaint may be a method of transferring responsibility. A disagreement may be an opportunity to provoke reassurance, establish moral superiority, or force the other person into submission.

This distinction is essential because the visible conversation often has little to do with the real game.

Suppose someone repeatedly asks for your advice, rejects every suggestion, explains why nothing will work, and returns several days later with the same problem. You may think your task is to produce better advice. It is not. The advice is merely the surface transaction. The hidden payoff may be continued attention without personal responsibility.

As long as you keep supplying new solutions, the game continues.

The rational response is not to become more persuasive. It is to change the transaction. Instead of offering another solution, ask what action the person is prepared to take. Require a decision. Attach your further

involvement to visible effort. The moment attention becomes conditional on action, the hidden payoff disappears.

This principle applies far beyond advice. Whenever a conversation feels repetitive, emotionally exhausting, and strangely resistant to resolution, assume that the stated issue may not be the real issue.

Look for what is being gained through continuation.

Behaviour Reveals the Real Incentive

People describe themselves through words, but they reveal themselves through repeated choices.

A person may claim to value peace while continually initiating conflict. They may say they want independence while arranging their life so that others must rescue them. They may insist that they respect you while repeatedly testing what they can get away with. They may speak constantly about loyalty while abandoning obligations whenever loyalty becomes expensive.

Do not waste too much time reconciling the contradiction. The behaviour tells you which payoff is dominant.

Robert Greene repeatedly emphasizes the importance of watching moves rather than becoming hypnotized by words. Emotional self-control allows you to observe the pattern as if it were a position on a chessboard. Once you stop taking each move personally, you become capable of studying what the move is designed to produce.

When someone insults you, for example, the insult may be less important than the desired reaction. They may want anger so they can portray you as unstable. They may want an explanation so they can place you in a defensive position. They may want visible insecurity because it confirms that they have influence over you.

The careless response is to answer the content of the insult.

The strategic response is to deny the intended result.

This does not always mean silence. It means responding according to your objective rather than according to the emotion they attempted to create. Sometimes the correct response is a calm correction.

Sometimes it is withdrawal. Sometimes it is a consequence. Sometimes it is a simple refusal to continue the interaction.

The central question is not, "How do I prove them wrong?"

It is, "What response makes this behaviour unprofitable?"

Attention Is Often the First Reward to Remove

People underestimate the value of attention because it does not look like a material resource. Yet attention can provide recognition, emotional stimulation, status, reassurance, conflict, and a sense of control.

The human hunger for recognition is insatiable. People structure social time through rituals, pastimes, activities, intimacy, and games partly because unstructured social emptiness is uncomfortable. Even negative recognition can be preferable to being ignored.

This explains why certain people repeatedly provoke reactions that appear unpleasant even for them. The conflict itself may satisfy a deeper need. It confirms their importance. It forces everyone to respond to them. It transforms their internal discomfort into a shared external crisis.

When you answer every provocation, you may be paying the person for provoking you.

The first practical rule is therefore to separate communication from access. Someone does not automatically deserve an extended conversation merely because they created an emotional disturbance. You can acknowledge a legitimate issue without rewarding the method used to raise it.

A useful response sounds like this:

“I am willing to discuss the problem when we can discuss it normally.”

This does three things. It confirms that the issue has not been ignored, refuses to reward aggression, and makes future access conditional on behavioural adjustment.

The wording matters less than the structure. You are not trying to win the emotional exchange. You are teaching the person which form of behaviour gains access to you.

The same rule applies to digital communication, work, family, friendship, and negotiation. Do not give your fastest responses to the people who create the most artificial urgency. Do not give the longest explanations to the people who make the most reckless accusations. Do not give the greatest concessions to the people who become the most dramatic.

Otherwise, you train everyone around you to become urgent, accusatory, and dramatic.

A Boundary Without Enforcement Is Information

Many people believe they have established a boundary because they clearly stated what they will not tolerate.

They have only provided information.

A boundary becomes real when crossing it changes something.

The change does not need to be theatrical. It may involve reduced access, delayed assistance, withdrawal from a project, altered terms, a formal record, the loss of a privilege, or the end of an arrangement. What matters is that the consequence is connected, proportionate, and credible.

Game theory is useful here because it forces you to examine incentives across repeated interactions. A punishment that will never be enforced cannot shape behaviour. A threat that damages you more than the other person is not credible. A rule that disappears whenever someone applies enough pressure will invite further pressure.

In repeated games, cooperation can often be supported when rewards and punishments are constructed so that deviation is less attractive than continued cooperation. But the incentives must be credible, and the mechanism must survive the moment when enforcement becomes inconvenient.

This is why extreme threats usually fail. “Do that again and I will never speak to you” may sound powerful, but if you are obviously unwilling to end the relationship, the threat weakens your position. A smaller consequence that you will certainly enforce is stronger than a catastrophic consequence everyone knows you will abandon.

Instead of threatening total destruction, reduce access by one level.

Instead of announcing that an employee will be fired, document the failure and remove control over the affected responsibility.

Instead of telling a client that you will walk away, require payment in advance for additional work.

Instead of declaring that a friendship is over, stop offering privileges that the friendship no longer justifies.

Good boundaries are rarely emotional. They are administrative.

They change the terms under which the relationship continues.

Never Rescue People From the Consequences That Teach Them

One of the most common ways people preserve destructive behaviour is by protecting others from its natural consequences.

A competent employee repeatedly covers for an incompetent colleague. A disciplined partner repeatedly absorbs the cost of another person's irresponsibility. A reliable family member solves every emergency created by poor planning. A business owner keeps repairing the damage caused by a client who refuses to respect the process.

The rescuer believes he is solving the immediate problem. In reality, he may be preserving its cause.

When someone receives the benefit of irresponsible behaviour while another person absorbs the cost, the structure rewards irresponsibility. The irresponsible person has little incentive to change because the system has separated their decisions from their consequences.

This does not mean you should become indifferent to every mistake. Strategic judgment requires distinguishing between an accident, an early learning error, and an established pattern.

Help is valuable when it increases future competence.

Help becomes destructive when it replaces competence.

Before rescuing someone, ask what your intervention teaches. Does it teach them how to solve the problem next time, or does it teach them that you will solve it every time? Does your help reduce dependence, or does it make dependence more comfortable?

The best assistance transfers capability. It may include a process, a deadline, a standard, or temporary support. It should leave the person more responsible than before.

Repeated rescue usually leaves them less responsible.

Control the Dynamic, Not Every Move

Weak strategists try to control every action another person takes. This creates constant supervision, exhaustion, resentment, and rebellion. Strong strategists shape the environment in which actions are chosen.

The distinction between fighting individual battles and controlling the larger dynamic is crucial. A person who controls the pace, available choices, stakes, and direction of an interaction often holds more power than the person who appears more aggressive. Control comes from defining the situation so that the other party's best available response also advances your position.

Suppose a client regularly requests last-minute revisions. You could argue over every request. That leaves the client in control of the tempo because they decide when the next emergency occurs.

A stronger approach is to change the system. The contract now includes a defined revision window, a fixed number of revisions, and an additional charge for expedited changes. You no longer need to debate whether each request is reasonable. The structure processes the request for you.

Suppose an employee continually interrupts your work with questions they could answer themselves. You could respond each time and become progressively irritated. Or you could create two scheduled decision windows during the day and require non-urgent questions to wait.

Suppose a someone repeatedly draws you into circular arguments. You could become better at arguing. Or you could impose a twenty-minute limit and end discussions that return to already answered points.

The objective is to replace repeated acts of willpower with an arrangement that makes the preferred behaviour easier and the destructive behaviour more costly.

Control through structure is quieter than control through confrontation, but it is usually more durable.

Reputation Is a Behavioural Incentive

Your reputation changes how people calculate their behaviour before they deal with you.

If you are known for eventually surrendering after enough pressure, people will apply pressure. If you are known for making angry threats and abandoning them, people will wait out your anger. If you are known for being generous but precise, people will approach you differently. If you are known for documenting agreements, opportunists become more careful. If you are known for leaving bad arrangements without creating drama, others are less likely to assume that emotional attachment will trap you.

Reputation completes work before you enter the room.

You should treat reputation, competence, resources, legitimacy, and relationships as distinct sources of personal power. Reputation creates expectations, while competence makes your value harder to replace. The combination gives you leverage because people both expect a certain standard from you and incur a cost when they lose access to your contribution.

This means you should deliberately decide what behaviours your reputation will encourage.

You do not need to appear cruel. You need to appear consistent.

The ideal reputation is not “He always punishes people.”

It is “His words accurately predict his actions.”

That reputation reduces conflict because fewer people waste time testing rules that have repeatedly survived pressure.

Build it through small moments. Arrive when you say you will. Deliver what you promise. Decline what you cannot deliver. Correct small violations before they become customs. Never announce a consequence that you are unwilling to apply. Do not make exceptions merely to escape temporary discomfort.

People learn your character through accumulation.

Every tolerated violation teaches them something. Every enforced standard teaches them something else.

Use Backward Induction Before Entering Conflict

Most people enter conflict by deciding what they want to say.

Begin at the end.

Backward induction means looking at the likely final outcomes and reasoning backward through the decisions that lead to them. Game theory uses it to analyze sequential interactions in which each player anticipates how the other may respond.

Before confronting someone, ask what happens after the confrontation.

Suppose you accuse a colleague of undermining you. They will probably deny it. What evidence will you present? If the evidence is ambiguous, what happens next? Will the confrontation cause them to stop, or merely make them more careful? Will your superior view the conflict as useful information or as interpersonal drama? What outcome are you realistically able to enforce?

This analysis may reveal that direct confrontation is premature. You may first need to document a pattern, secure responsibilities in writing, reduce the colleague's access to your work, or speak privately with the relevant authority.

The same process applies to negotiations. Do not focus only on the opening request. Consider the likely counteroffer, your response, their alternative, your walk-away point, and what happens after either agreement or failure.

It also applies to boundaries. If the person violates the rule again, what precisely will you do? What will they do in response? Are you prepared for guilt, anger, silence, escalation, or reputation attacks? If not, strengthen your position before announcing the boundary.

Never start a conflict whose next stage you have not considered.

Emotional people plan the first move.

Strategic people plan the sequence.

Do Not Reward Apologies More Than Changed Behaviour

An apology can be sincere, but it can also become a device for resetting consequences without changing the pattern.

Some people become highly skilled at producing remorse immediately after misconduct. They offer explanations, self-criticism, affection, promises, and temporary compliance. Because the apology relieves emotional tension, the injured person accepts it as proof that the problem has been solved.

Then the behaviour returns.

The practical error is treating emotional intensity as evidence of behavioural change.

A better rule is to accept apologies socially while evaluating change operationally.

You do not need to argue with the apology. You can acknowledge it. But privileges should return gradually, after consistent behaviour makes restoration rational.

Trust should not be restored because someone found convincing words. It should be restored because the underlying incentives, habits, or circumstances have changed.

Ask what is materially different.

Has the person accepted a consequence? Have they changed the process that allowed the mistake? Have they volunteered transparency? Have they repaired the damage? Have they behaved differently when placed under the same pressure?

Remorse describes how someone feels about the past.

Reform changes what they are likely to do in the future.

Change Your Social Environment When the Game Cannot Be Reformed

Not every pattern should be corrected from inside the existing relationship.

People often select friends, associates, and intimates who play compatible psychological games. When someone stops participating in the established game, the group may resist, reject, or expel them. But the same person may become welcome in another social circle organized around different behaviour.

This explains why self-improvement sometimes creates social friction.

When you stop participating in gossip, the group does not merely lose a topic. It loses a ritual that helped establish belonging. When you stop rescuing irresponsible relatives, the family does not merely lose help. It loses the arrangement that allowed everyone else to avoid responsibility. When you become disciplined, old friends may interpret your new standards as judgment because your behaviour exposes the cost of their own choices.

You should not automatically abandon people whenever resistance appears. But you must recognize when the environment itself depends on keeping you in your former role.

Ask whether the group rewards the person you are trying to become.

Does it reward competence or mock effort? Does it respect boundaries or treat availability as an obligation? Does it encourage honest correction or punish anyone who disrupts the shared illusion? Does it give status for creating value, or for creating drama?

A man cannot indefinitely maintain standards inside an environment that imposes a social tax on every expression of those standards.

Sometimes the most strategic behavioural intervention is relocation.

The Hard Principle

You teach people how to deal with you through what you repeatedly reward, tolerate, rescue, and forgive without adjustment.

Words can clarify the rule, but only consequences establish it.

This principle also applies inwardly. Your own habits survive because they produce immediate payoffs. Procrastination provides relief. Indecision postpones responsibility. Anger protects the ego from shame. Distraction protects you from difficult work. Fantasizing about future success produces emotion without requiring present sacrifice.

You cannot defeat these patterns merely by condemning yourself. You must alter their payoff.

Make avoidance slightly more difficult. Make action easier to begin. Remove the immediate reward from the destructive behaviour. Attach visible satisfaction to completion. Reduce your options during important work. Stop depending on motivation when structure can remove the need for choice.

Whether you are leading yourself, managing others, negotiating, or protecting your time, the rule remains the same:

Stop asking behaviour to change while preserving everything that makes the behaviour rewarding.

Change the payoff, and the pattern is forced to adapt.

P.S. This post is only a small part of what has been preserved inside Fifty Shades of Sanity: The Forbidden Archive.

The archive is my private collection. It contains the deleted threads,

long-form essays, and private lessons on power, status, discipline, strategy, and human behavior that were too detailed to fit into a single post.

[You can access the full archive here](#)
